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ANALYTICS CONSULTANCY

FREE GUIDE · AI-READY DATA

AI-Ready Data

A 10-step guide for business owners and finance leads who want AI answers they can trust.

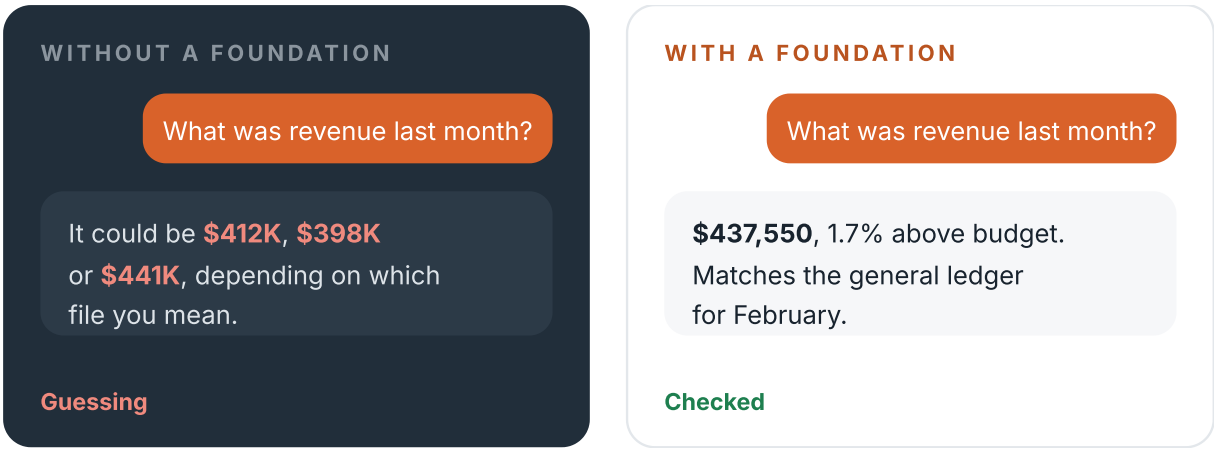
- Why AI is only as reliable as the data under it
- 10 practical steps, with warning signs and what good looks like
- A one-page checklist to score your business
- Plain language, no code

Zohal Zahir
Microsoft Fabric and Power BI consultant · Microsoft Partner · DP-600 · PL-300
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START HERE

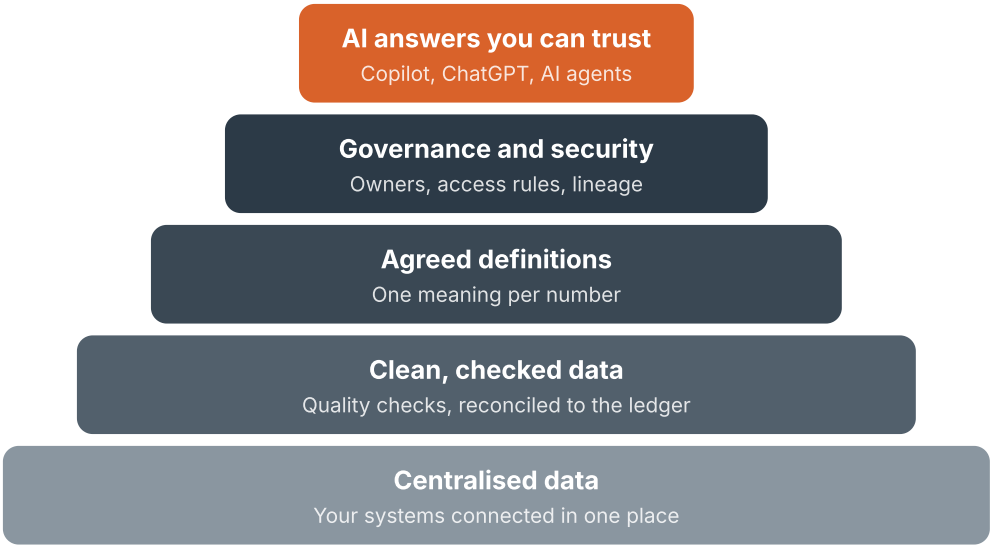
AI is only as reliable as the foundation under it

Copilot, ChatGPT and AI agents answer from the data and the context they are given. They do not know that your CRM and your accounts define "customer" differently, or that last month's spreadsheet has duplicates. They answer anyway, confidently.



The difference between the two answers is not a better AI tool. It is the foundation underneath: data that is **centralised**, **checked**, **defined** and **governed**. The same foundation also fixes everyday reporting, so the work pays off even before you use AI.

The foundation, layer by layer



The 10 steps build these layers from the bottom up. Use the checklist on page 8 to see where you stand.

STEPS 1–2 · KNOW WHAT YOU NEED

1 List the questions that matter

AI is useful only if it answers questions people actually ask.

Warning signs

- × Nobody can say which five questions leadership asks every month
- × Reports exist that nobody opens

What good looks like

- ✓ A written list of the 10 to 20 questions that drive decisions
- ✓ Each question linked to the number that answers it

QUICK CHECK

Can you name the five questions your leadership asks most?

2 Find every place your data lives

You cannot connect what you have not listed.

Warning signs

- × Key numbers sit in personal spreadsheets
- × Nobody knows which system is the source of truth

What good looks like

- ✓ A simple map: each system, what it holds, who owns it
- ✓ One named source for each key number

QUICK CHECK

Could you list every system and spreadsheet that feeds your monthly reporting?

STEPS 3–4 · CONNECT AND DEFINE

3 Bring your systems into one place

AI reads one connected picture far better than ten exports.

Warning signs

- × Monthly copy-and-paste between systems
- × Questions that cross systems take days

What good looks like

- ✓ Accounting, CRM, operations and spreadsheets load into one platform on a schedule
- ✓ No manual exports

QUICK CHECK

Can you answer profit by customer without opening Excel?

4 Agree one definition for each number

If "revenue" has three meanings, AI will use all three.

Warning signs

- × Two reports show different totals for the same month
- × Meetings start by arguing about whose number is right

What good looks like

- ✓ Each key measure defined once, signed off by the business
- ✓ The same definition used in every report

QUICK CHECK

Would finance and sales give the same answer to "what was revenue last month"?

STEPS 5–6 · DEFINE AND CHECK

5 Write the definitions where AI and people can read them

Plain-word descriptions are the context AI needs.

Warning signs

- × Definitions live in one person's head
- × Field names like REV_ADJ_2 with no explanation

What good looks like

- ✓ A short data dictionary in plain words
- ✓ Descriptions added to the Power BI model so Copilot can use them

QUICK CHECK

If a new manager asked what "active customer" means, where would they look?

6 Check the data before anyone uses it

Wrong data in means confident wrong answers out.

Warning signs

- × Duplicates, missing codes and blank dates found by accident
- × Reports corrected by hand before meetings

What good looks like

- ✓ Automatic checks for missing, duplicate and out-of-range values
- ✓ Totals reconciled to the accounting system every refresh

QUICK CHECK

Do your reports match your accounting system without manual adjustments?

STEPS 7–8 · MONITOR AND OWN

7 Get alerted when something breaks

A silent failure is worse than no report at all.

Warning signs

- × A source stopped updating weeks ago and nobody noticed
- × Refresh errors discovered in the board meeting

What good looks like

- ✓ An alert within hours if a source stops or a check fails
- ✓ A named person who acts on it

QUICK CHECK

Would you know today if one of your data sources stopped updating yesterday?

8 Give every dataset an owner

Someone must be accountable for each number.

Warning signs

- × Anyone can change a shared spreadsheet
- × Nobody can say who approved a definition

What good looks like

- ✓ A business owner for each dataset
- ✓ Changes tracked and reversible

QUICK CHECK

For your top five numbers, can you name who owns each one?

STEPS 9–10 · SECURE AND SUSTAIN

9 Control who sees what

AI answers from whatever data a person can reach.

Warning signs

- × Everyone can see salaries, margins or every region
- × Security that worked in testing but not after launch

What good looks like

- ✓ Row-level security so each person sees only their rows
- ✓ Tested for each role before go-live, and again after changes

QUICK CHECK

If a branch manager asked Copilot about another branch, what would it show them?

10 Make it run without one person

A foundation that depends on one person is not a foundation.

Warning signs

- × Only one person knows how the reporting works
- × Reporting stops when that person is on leave

What good looks like

- ✓ Documented, version-controlled and refreshed automatically
- ✓ At least two people trained to run and change it

QUICK CHECK

Could someone else run your reporting next month if the builder left?

CHECKLIST

Score your foundation

Tick each statement that is true for your business today. Each tick is one point.

- ☐ We have a written list of the questions that drive our decisions.
- ☐ We know every system and spreadsheet that feeds our reporting.
- ☐ Our key systems load into one place automatically.
- ☐ Each key number has one agreed definition.
- ☐ Those definitions are written down in plain words.
- ☐ Data is checked automatically and reconciled to our accounts.
- ☐ We are alerted within a day if a source stops updating.
- ☐ Every key dataset has a named owner.
- ☐ People only see the data they are allowed to see, and it is tested.
- ☐ Our reporting would keep running if the person who built it left.

Score	What it means	Where to start
8–10	Strong foundation. You are close to AI-ready.	Review definitions and security, then pilot Copilot on one report.
4–7	Some foundations in place. AI would give answers, some wrong.	Fix the unticked items in steps 3 to 7 first.
0–3	Foundation needed. AI would be guessing.	Start with steps 1 to 4. This also fixes everyday reporting.

PREFER TO DO IT ONLINE?

Take the free 3-minute scorecard at **datasanj.com/ai-ready-scorecard.html** for an instant score by area and the three things to fix first.

WHAT IT TAKES

How long does a foundation take?

It depends on how many systems you have and how clean they are. As a rough guide for a small or mid-size business:

Starting point	Typical first phase	What you get
One accounting system and a few spreadsheets	2–4 weeks	Automated month-end reporting, agreed definitions, reconciled to the ledger
Three to five systems (accounting, CRM, operations)	6–10 weeks, in stages	One governed model on Microsoft Fabric, data checks, alerts, security
Many sites or companies	Phased over several months	Group and site reporting on one model, each phase signed off

Ranges are indicative only. A short discovery confirms scope and a fixed price before any build.

Common mistakes to avoid

- × **Buying AI before fixing data.** The tool is rarely the problem; the data underneath is.
- × **Building dashboards before agreeing definitions.** A better chart shows the wrong number faster.
- × **Skipping security.** AI answers from whatever data a person can reach, including data they should not see.
- × **Relying on one person.** Document, version-control and train a second person.

> *"She is very detailed and able to take what I gave her to create something that will save me hours each month." — Client, nonprofit organisation (month-end automation)*



Want a second pair of eyes on your foundation?

DATASANJ builds centralised, governed, AI-ready data on Microsoft Fabric and Power BI for small and mid-size businesses. Fixed price, built in your own Microsoft account, and fixed free for 30 days after handover if anything does not work as agreed.

Book a free 30-minute call

datasanj.com · d_zohal@datasanj.com · +61 435 916 536
linkedin.com/in/dr-zohal-zahir-46128697

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